



Reading: Supplemental Reading for Windows Update

Windows Update

The Windows operating system updates frequently. These updates often include important security patches. It is important to keep your Windows systems up to date with the most current changes. This reading covers the different types of Windows updates and how to install them.

The Windows OS includes the Windows Update Client service. This service runs in the background on your computer to help you download and install updates and patches for the operating system. It does this by checking in with the Windows Update servers at Microsoft and looking for updates that should be applied to your computer. If your Windows system is functioning properly, the Windows Update Client will alert you when there are updates to install.

Types of Windows updates

There are several types of updates that the Windows Update Client might find for your Windows system.

- **Critical updates** address critical bugs that are not security related. These are widely released fixes for a specific problem.
- **Definition updates** are widely released and frequent updates to a product's definition database. Definition databases are used to detect specific types of objects on your system, such as malicious code, phishing websites, or junk mail.
- **Driver updates:** Drivers are software that control the input and output of devices running on your system. This software may be updated when new versions of the driver become available for your devices or if you install a new device on your system.
- **Feature packs** add new product functionality to your system. This functionality is first distributed as an update to a product currently running on your system. It is usually included in the next full product release.
- **Security updates** are widely released patches for a security related vulnerability. Security vulnerabilities are rated by severity as being critical, important, moderate, or low.

- a) **Critical** vulnerabilities pose an active threat. *Patch should be installed immediately.*
- b) **Important** vulnerabilities pose a likely threat. *Patch should be installed as soon as possible.*
- c) **Moderate** vulnerabilities pose a potential threat. *Patch should be installed soon.*
- d) **Low** severity vulnerabilities are not an immediate threat, but a *patch is recommended.*

- **Service packs** collect all tested hotfixes, security updates, critical updates, and general updates together and distribute them as a set. A service pack also may contain new fixes or design changes requested by customers.
- **General updates** are widely released fixes for specific problems. They address noncritical bugs that are not security related.
- **Update rollups** collect a set of tested hotfixes and updates that target a specific area, such as a component or service. These fixes and updates are packaged together for easy deployment.
- **Security-only updates** collect all the new security updates from a given month for distribution through the Windows Server Update Services (see below). These updates are called “Security Only Quality Update” when you download them and will be rated as “Important.”
- **New OS:** A new version of the Windows operating system may also be deployed through the Windows Update Client. For example, Windows 10 and 11 were both delivered as updates to a previously installed OS.

Installing updates

The process for installing updates may be automatic, depending on which version of Windows you’re using

Automatic updates

Beginning with Windows 10, the Windows OS ships with automatic updates turned on. With automatic updates on, Windows Update Client will download and install available updates without prompting you. For older versions of Windows, you must configure Windows Update to update automatically.

Windows 10 and 11 no longer allow you to turn off automatic updates completely, but you can pause updates for up to 35 days. Once the pause period ends, you are required to perform an update before you can pause again.

Manual updates

You can manually prompt Windows to perform an update at any time by checking for updates with the Windows Update tool. Manually updating does vary based on the version of Windows used. For detailed instructions on how to do this, see the [Windows Update: FAQ page](#).

To ensure top performance and security for your Windows system you should make sure it is always updated to the most recent changes.

Key takeaways

The Windows operating system updates frequently, so it is important that you know how to keep your Windows systems up to date with the most current changes.

- Windows operating systems include the Windows Update Client service to help you download and install updates and patches for the operating system.

- There are several types of updates that the Windows Update Client might find for your Windows system.
 - The process for installing updates depends on which version of Windows you're using.
 - Regular updates ensure top performance and security for your Windows system.
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